together with all such things as ‘might be deemed advisable or desirable for efficiently carrying [the project] into effect’. To this end, the railway company was empowered to enter into contracts with ‘Her Majesty’s government in this country [Great Britain] or in India, or with the Honourable East India Company’ so that ‘one or more line or lines of railway’ could be constructed and maintained. The company contracted with the Indian government for a 4–5 per cent guaranteed return on the funds needed to construct lines from Madras (now Chennai) to Vaypura (now Beypore), and from Madras to the Bombay line. This amounted to a stretch of 820 miles. Construction began on the first section of the company’s network in 1853. The first train ran along the completed line from Chennai to Wallajah Road in 1856. Construction continued and the Madras railway network expanded significantly. [56] The hot weather of the south called for certain measures to keep the rail carriages comparatively cooler. They were made to certain specifications and had glass windows to keep the compartment cool, and had leather curtains to distinguish first class from the rest. There were also fourth class freight trains for the masses. The following excerpts from the official correspondence of George Bruce, a British engineer, with an observation letter written by the consulting engineer, T.T. Pears, gives an insight. [57]

Madras Railway
Coimbatore, 24 December 1853
Edward Smalley, Esquire, Agent

Sir,
I have the honour to forward to you some drawings of railway carriages made by Mr Simpson, the coach builder, Madras .

I think it desirable that the carriages should not be very large to avoid the difficulty which would be experienced in moving them at the stations if very heavy; this would lead me to prefer four-wheeled carriages to six-wheeled ones.

It would be an advantage to have the steps of the carriages so extended as to enable the guard to move without danger along the train, and to assist in this a hand rail might be placed the whole length of the carriage on each side.

The ventilation of carriages is a matter of great importance; and this will probably be best secured by spaces left in the sides, both below and above, covered with rattan [58] as shown in the drawing, and by venetians to slide up and down, as in a gentleman’s ordinary carriage in this country.

On the other hand, to keep out the intense heat and hot winds, the first class carriages should in addition to venetians have glass windows, as at home, and strong leather purdahs to keep off the glare of the sun.

And in addition to this, both first and second class carriages should have a double roof.